

Hong Kong

Hong Kong is a special administrative region in southeast China, made up of 236 islands and a mainland area. It has a busy port and is a leading financial centre. More than six million people live there. A former British colony, Hong Kong was returned to China in 1997. It experienced economic setbacks after the transition, but is now recovering.



Gambling

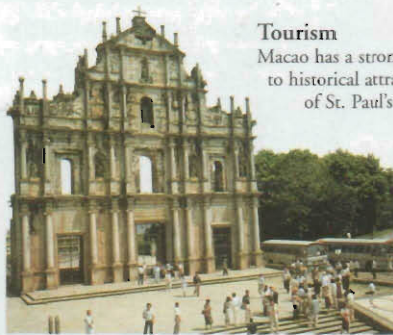
Gambling is a popular activity in Hong Kong. Playing mahjong, a traditional game, with friends and family is a way of socializing. Horse racing is a big industry, with many people placing bets online.

Houseboats

Some Hong Kong fishing families live in houseboats called sampans, which are moored in the harbours. The fishermen are now facing increasing competition from more efficient deep-sea trawlers.

Macao

A tiny peninsula in southeast China, Macao became a Portuguese colony nearly 450 years ago and was returned to China in 1999. Situated about 64 km (40 miles) west of Hong Kong, Macao is a popular tourist destination, with fragrant woods, and a sandy coastline onto the South China Sea.



Tourism

Macao has a strong tourist industry due to historical attractions such as the ruins of St. Paul's Church, built by the Portuguese in 1602.

Macao's greatest attraction, however, are the casinos that bring the territory about one third of its total income. The economy has been in decline since the handover to China.

Taiwan



Often referred to as a "Little Dragon", Taiwan has one of Asia's most rapidly expanding economies. However, it is not recognized by the UN and lies at the centre of a debate over ruling rights. China claims Taiwan to be a province of Beijing, although the Taiwanese have governed here since the communists gained control of China in 1949. Despite this tension, Taiwan has established global trading markets, and its people enjoy high living standards.



Opera

Traditional Chinese opera was brought to the island with settlers from China. The operas are based on traditional stories. Stage sets are basic, but the costumes are elaborate, made from richly coloured silks with delicate embroidery. Make-up is used to highlight emotions.



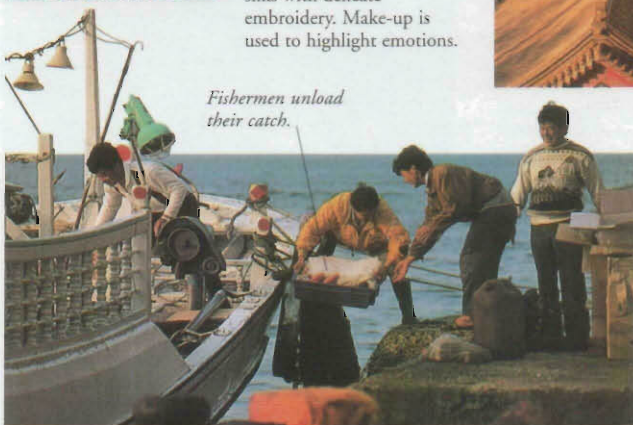
People

About 84 per cent of Taiwanese are Han Chinese, who moved to Taiwan when the communists took power in 1949. They live in extended family groups, following traditional customs. Taiwan's native peoples of Indonesian origin now make up only two per cent of the population. The Ami, of the eastern mountains, are the largest group. Expert potters and farmers, their women rule the household.



Sun Moon Lake

Taiwan's scenic Sun Moon Lake, known as *Jih-yüeh Tan*, is surrounded by the Central Mountains. The two parts of the lake, Sun Lake and Moon Lake, supply a hydroelectric plant that produces four per cent of the country's power. The tranquil, forested area is known for its ornate buildings, including the Buddhist Wen Wu Temple.



Fishermen unload their catch.

Fishing

Taiwan's fishermen land 1,171,000 tonnes (1,290,793 tons) of fish annually from the rich fishing grounds surrounding the island. Some Taiwanese fishermen have been accused of plundering Atlantic fishing grounds. Much of the catch goes to supply the huge Japanese market. Freshwater ponds are used for farming carp.

TAIWAN FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Taipei
AREA	32,260 sq km (12,456 sq miles)
POPULATION	22,200,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Mandarin Chinese
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Buddhist, traditional beliefs
CURRENCY	Taiwan dollar
LIFE EXPECTANCY	76 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	894
GOVERNMENT	Multi-party democracy
ADULT LITERACY	94%



Taipei

The high-tech capital in the north of the island is the fastest growing city in Asia, having expanded to four times its original size. Many of the three million inhabitants ride to work on motor scooters, causing pollution and jams.

Industry

Few natural resources have forced Taiwan to develop a booming, highly specialized industry. Backed by an educated, ambitious work-force, the country exports electronic equipment, such as computers and television sets, machinery, textiles, sports equipment, toys, and watches. Profits are invested, or used to buy oil for energy. Farming and fishing ensure self-sufficiency in food.